

Sonder

A Portfolio

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By

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“Man is but a dream of a shadow”

- *Pindar, Pythian 8 ode*

The morning the man came, I was still green.

Not the deep green of the leaves above, but the pale, thin-skinned green that meant I was close to gold. My brothers pressed against me in the bunch, our sides warm from days of sun. We had been ripening for weeks--slow, patient work. The air was heavy, humming with insects. Below, the jungle whispered: wings, paws, the slither of something unseen. But none of it frightened me. Nothing even had.

The jungle held us the way a hand holds its own palm.

Its light was always soft here, layered through the canopy like a blanket spread over sleeping bodies. Every sound belonged to something I knew: the drone of insects tracing lazy spirals in the heat, the hustle of small wings shifting from branch to branch, the distant rhythm of gorillas setting arguments by beating their chests.

I understood this place without needing to think. The patterns of light that changed with the hours. The way the wind curled around the trunk before it reached us. The shape of each of our shadows on the ground.

I wanted to stay longer. Another week, maybe two, and I'd be perfect: yellow through and through, sweet enough that even the birds would come.

But the man had other plans.

I heard him before I saw him: machete slicing through the brush, boots dragging through mud, breath huffing in rhythm with each swing. His voice drifted up to us: half words, half grunts, as if speaking to the jungle itself.

He stopped beneath our tree. Looked up. His face was shadowed by a wide boonie hat, but I could see his eyes search the bunch. His hand rose. He squeezed my brother on the end--too hard. My brother flinched, skin bruising beneath his thumb.

"Too green," the man muttered.

Relief flooded through me. We had more time!

But his fingers kept moving: testing, pressing, until they reached me.

His palm was rough, blistered from gripping the blade. He pulled me slightly away from my brothers, enough to expose the soft stem that held me there. I tried to stay firm, to prove I wasn't ready, to remind him I still belonged.

His thumb pressed into me. Not breaking the peel, but close.

“This one’s better,” he said, low.

No, I wasn’t better! Just sunburned from where a leaf had torn away days ago. I wanted to cry out, but the air stayed still.

The machete flashed, a slice of light in the green gloom. My brothers shuddered beside me. The blade rose and came down.

Not through the stalk.

Through me.

I felt the tear--hot, fast, wrong. A split of self from self. My stem gave, my body swung free. The air rushed cold against the spot where I’d been attached. My brothers reached for me without moving, their skins gleaming in the filtered light. I could almost hear them scream, *stay*.

The mean’s hand held me aloft. Below, sap dripped onto the mud like blood.

He carried me through the heat, laid me in a wooden crate that smelled of sap and salt. Inside, other fruit breathed their slow sweetness. Between the slats, flickered like thin gold blades. Each jolt of the truck jarred through the crate, rattling me against the others.

That was when I thought of my father. He had been picked two months before: from the next tree over. I had watched the same machete, the same arc of silver. I'd told myself he was lucky, chosen for his strength, his perfect yellow. But when the night came, our bunch had swayed in silence.

Father had a way of speaking that made the jungle small, not because he meant to shrink it, but because he described everything in terms of us.

If a bird landed nearby, he'd murmur, "It comes to admire us."

If the wind passed through the leaves, he'd say, "Hear how it sings for us?"

If rain tickled and gathered on our skins, "It remembers us."

He wasn't teaching anything, really. It was just the way he talked, as if the jungle began at our stems and ended at our tree's leaves.

I didn't question him.

Why would I?

So when the man cut father away, I told myself a story he might have told: reminding myself that the world could still belong to us, even if we were no longer together.

But now, rattling in the cage, the road jarring through my bruised skin, I'm not so sure.

Still, I find myself wishing I had grown slower--that if I had stayed green, I'd still be there with them. But another part of me had wanted this: the leaving, the unknown. Maybe I was ripening towards escape.

And then, shame. Because when I hated myself for leaving, I would still circle my own reflection. Whether I praised myself or condemned myself, I was still saying *me, me, me*.

We bananas live in bunches. We learn together, grow together, fall together. But when am I now, alone in the crate, jostled through mud and noise.

The truck lurched to a stop. Voices rose and fell outside, sharp, hurried, unfamiliar. Then the air shifted.

A new smell drifted in through the slats.

Not the damp green breath of the jungle, nor the warm sweetness of my brother's ripening beside me. This scent was colder, metallic, as if the world had been scraped down to its bare bones. It pricked at my peel.

Then: light. A pale, shimmered kind I had never seen in the jungle. It flickered against the wood, always in motion, trembling like a living thing.

I edged toward the gap.

And the world opened.

A vastness. A moving sky laid a flare across the earth. Blue, but not one blue. Thousands. Shifting, folding, swallowing, and releasing light in great, slow breaths. It glittered like the wings of insects. It roared softly, but without anger. It stretched farther than treetops, farther than anything I had ever seen.

I started until I ached.

This couldn't be water. Water was something that slid down our skins after rain, gathered in puddles beneath our roots, and clung to us like cool fingers. Water was small, soothing, ours. Water was consumed, but it did not consume.

The wind that reached me on the dock carried a sting to it: dry, bright, impatient. It rushed over my peel in quick strokes, as if trying to scrub the jungle smell off me. Beneath us, the boards gave a long, hollow shudder each time someone stepped; the sound traveled through the crates like a distant heartbeat.

The world here felt stretched open. No canopy above. No trunks hemming anything in. Just a sweep of sky so wide it made me feel suddenly narrow, like the air might pass straight through me if I didn't hold myself together.

Through the slats, I caught flashes of movement: ropes coiling and uncoiling, hands tugging at nets, buckets swinging in arcs of water that hit the dock in dull slaps. Everywhere, the smell of the sea pressed close: something cold and mineral, something that had never touched a leaf in its life.

Light scattered across the surface below in restless patches. It didn't settle on it the way it settled on leaves; it fractured, broke apart, reshaped itself with every breath of wind, as if the water were thinking. The blue shifted every time the air breathed, like a giant lung, filling and emptying.

The dock trembled again, and I felt a shadow lengthen over me.

Not from a passing cloud.

From wings.

A tall bird, pure white from crown to tail, stood at the edge of the planks. Its legs were thin but steady, its posture alert, almost ceremonial. Its beak angled downward, too straight to be gentle, too still to be anything but deliberate. It wasn't scanning the crate. It was choosing.

Its gaze landed on me with a stillness that felt like pressure.

A breath later, the bird stepped forward. Its wings lifted, vast and pale, drawing a single cool draft of air that seeped into the crate. Before I could trace that chill, the break slid into the slats.

Its grip closed around my middle.

The world snapped open.

Wind hit me first.

A fast, clean rush, threading through the small tear in my peel. The dock spun away beneath me, the board shrinking into thin stripes. The shouts of men blurred into the howling of the winds. Boats, ropes, buckets, all the sharp edges of the harbor, tilted and twisted as the bird rose with an uneven, powerful beat.

I dangled below its beat, my body swinging in long arcs. With each swing, the horizon bent, sometimes a band of sky, sometimes a glint of water, sometimes a dizzying mixture of both. The bird's wings pumped the air into loud, steady bursts, sending tremors through me with every downstroke.

Someone yelled. A rope struck something hard. A gull shrieked overhead.

The heron halted sideways, startled.

For an instant, I felt myself held: caught between the force of the wings and the pull of gravity.

Then the grip around me loosened.

I hung suspended, weightless, twisting in a sky that seemed to last forever. Time slowed. The docks, the gulls, the shouting sailors all stretched into thin threads of sound and color, stretching around me like the waves below.

For a moment, I was flying. For a moment, I was suspended between heaven and earth, between the heron's beak and the liquid vastness below.

Then, inevitably, I tipped. Gravity reclaimed me. Everything let go.

And I fell.

The sea rose, vast and open. The air rushed. For a heartbeat, everything stilled: sky, salt, sound. I thought of my brothers, of my father, of the warm press of the bunch.

Then the slap. The cold. The shock. My peel shivered from the shock. The sound vanished at once, swallowed. Everything became muffled, rounded, as if the world had taken a deep breath and pulled me into its chest.

I expected sinking to feel like falling, but it felt more like being carried. Water folded over me, a blanket of weight and light. Light broke above me: trembling gold ribbons that twisted with the surface. I tumbled through blue, down past silver fish and waving fronds of seaweed. The sea spoke in creaks and murmurs, a language of pressure and vibrations. The fish brushed against me, curious. They nudged my skin with tiny, sharp snouts, then flicked away in shimmers of scales. The seaweed wrapped soft tendrils around my peel as if to welcome me home, like fingers trying to understand me by feel alone.

A current caught me and pulled.

Not down, not up: sideways. My bruises softened, then loosened. A thin thread of yellow lifted from my peel and spiraled upward, a strand that disappeared into the blue.

The deeper I sank, the darker it grew. My skin loosened bits of me floating off like golden threads.

I realized then that the sea did not hold anything tightly.

It didn't cling or claim like the stalk.

It simply lets things go.

Piece by piece, if it had to.

I thought of my father again--not as lost, but dissolved, returned. Maybe he was here too,
scattered though this endless blue.

The sea held me.

The big blue sea.

The sea.

Blue.

I did not have a word for it when I hung from the tree: when I was only green, when my world was nothing larger than the darkness between my brother's bodies and the light that filtered down in trembling leaves. Back then, the jungle was simply a stage on which we ripened, and I thought of everything as an extension of us: the sun existed to warm us; the rain existed to fatten us; the wind existed to cradle us while we slept. Even the distant rustle of animals felt incidental, just background to our slow golden transformation. What purpose did the world have, if not to witness us changing?

But now, drifting in this vast blue where even my shape is dissolving, I finally feel the size of everything that is not me. And in that size, the smallness of my life.

I am dissolving into a world full of beings who have never known me, who will never know me, and yet I will nourish them: algae, currents, small drifting lives that pass by only for moments. They will not know who I am, but they will carry something of me, and that is enough.